

XGA

XGA projectors, quite naturally, dominate the image quality benchmarks, where resolution is the main criterion. They have an upper hand in the picture tests and the text and presentation tests. But when it comes to DVDs, they do not make much of a difference to the image quality. That's why the movie test gives you a better insight to the absolute quality of the projector across the SVGA and XGA categories. This segment didn't have a single LCD projector.

Presentation Test

The Sharp XR-10X was the clear winner with its superb well-rounded performance. The other two were plagued with phase problems, with the Infocus faring badly—its performance was comparable to the under-performers in the SVGA segment. Text quality was the worst with the Infocus, with HP coming in second to Sharp. The graphs and pictures were severely affected on the Infocus.

DisplayMate Video Edition

The Infocus LP-600 fared pretty badly with the black levels. In fact, it was not able to produce anywhere near an authentic black. Even the white levels had a lot of problems with definition. The HP MP-2225, too, had below-average black levels, but it was much better than the Infocus. The Sharp XR-10x, like its sibling, gave outstanding results with black and white rendition.

The severe phase and tracking issues of the Infocus meant that it consistently under-performed in the sharpness and resolution tests. There was a lot of vertical banding apparent in the resolution tests. The HP fared better here. The pin-sharp resolution of the Sharp was so good that on closer inspection, we found that each pixel was rendered with absolute detail. This is absolutely unmatched by any projector in this comparison test. The Infocus ran into real trouble, with the phase problems giving it the worst rating in the moiré pattern tests across the entire test range.

The Infocus showed a fair bit of streaking and ghosting, while the HP gave decent results with not much of it apparent from the viewing position. The Sharp, again, was flawless in this respect. However, in the white and black level-shift and colour purity tests, the HP and Infocus were neck-to-neck with their scores, with only the red colour having accuracy problems with the Infocus. Both the HP and Infocus had issues rendering the 16 intensity-levels properly.

The Movie And Animation Tests

The upper-end DLP projectors in this segment showed better colour fidelity in movies and animation. In fact, they make movies worth watching with the DLP artefacts only apparent during very

stressing passages of the *Corrs* DVDs. The Sharp XR-10X quite naturally dominated the other two; note that the improvement over its cheaper SVGA version was quite negligible. In fact, even though the XGA version of the Sharp showed slightly more detail, we found the cheaper SVGA model to have a slightly better accuracy at colour gradation. This is because the lower pixel count (480,000 pixels) of the SVGA panel of the XR-10S puts less strain over the same image processor found in both the projectors, as compared to the higher pixel count (786,432) of the XGA panel, which makes the colour response sluggish. This was bought to the fore by the *Corrs Live in London* DVD, with a small amount of colour gradation problems visible in the XGA model of the Sharp. The SVGA version rendered the colours in the DVDs without a hitch, even at the high-intensity passages, where all the other projectors faltered.

Picture Quality

The Sharp comes out tops with class-leading resolution and colour-reproduction. Both the HP and the Infocus have their own problems with rendering pictures, but ultimately the HP does beat



Sharp XR-10S

it by a small margin. The XGA projectors are ideally suitable for displaying pictures due the sheer resolution afforded by them. But projectors such as the Sharp XR-10S SVGA show that a good SVGA can easily beat average XGA projectors such as the HP and the Infocus as far as image quality is concerned. Higher pixel count can never be a substitute for good engineering!

Conclusion

In the SVGA category, we had a total of five projectors. The Sharp XR-10S dominated with its brilliant performance and on-par features. Its striking performance completely overshadowed its asking price, and it gets the Digit Best Buy Gold. BenQ's MP-610 did put up a commendable performance, but was no way near to what the Sharp had on offer. If you're looking for a projector for your conference room, we'd suggest the Sharp XR-10S despite its high price.

Since the XGA category had only three entries, we did not think it wise to declare a winner. However, the Sharp XR-10X does deserve a mention for its brilliant performance. The HP MP-2225 did perform adequately, but fell way short of the standards set by the Sharp projectors. ■

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